



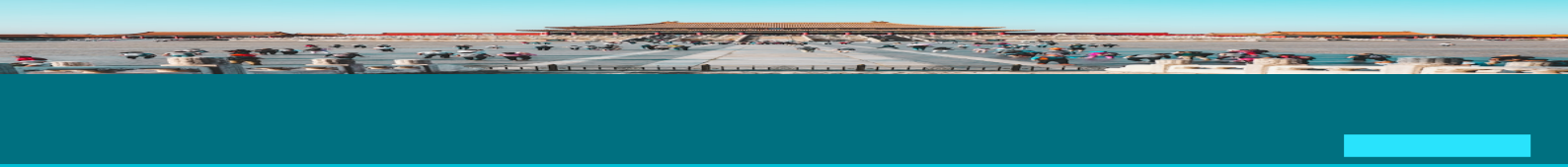
Travel & Adventure

Hidden gems, travel tips, and must-visit destinations



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Article 1

10 Must-Visit UNESCO World Heritage Sites in China

China has 57 UNESCO World Heritage Sites -- the most in the world alongside Italy. Here are the top 10 that every traveler should experience.

1. The Great Wall (长城)

-- Beijing area

Over 21,000 km of ancient fortifications. Best sections: Mutianyu (restored, less crowded), Jinshanling (photography), Badaling (most accessible). Entry: ¥40-65. Open 7:30 AM - 5:30 PM.

2. Terracotta Army (兵马俑)

-- Xi'an



Over 8,000 life-size warrior sculptures from 210 BC, guarding Emperor Qin Shi Huang's mausoleum. Three excavation pits open to visitors. Entry: ¥120. Allow 3-4 hours.

3. Forbidden City (故宫)

-- Beijing

600-year-old imperial palace with 9,999 rooms across 72 hectares. The world's largest palace complex. Entry: ¥60 (Apr-Oct), ¥40 (Nov-Mar). Book tickets online in advance.

4. West Lake (西湖)

-- Hangzhou

Inspired countless poems and paintings. Cycle around the lake, visit Leifeng Pagoda, take a boat to Three Pools Mirroring the Moon. Free entry to the lake area.

5. Zhangjiajie National Forest Park

-- Hunan



The inspiration for Avatar's floating mountains. Glass bridge, cable cars, and stunning sandstone pillars. Entry: ¥225 (4-day pass).

6. Jiuzhaigou Valley

-- Sichuan

Crystal-clear turquoise lakes, multi-tiered waterfalls, and snow-capped peaks. Best in autumn (Oct-Nov) for spectacular foliage. Entry: ¥169-250.

7. Mount Huangshan (黄山)

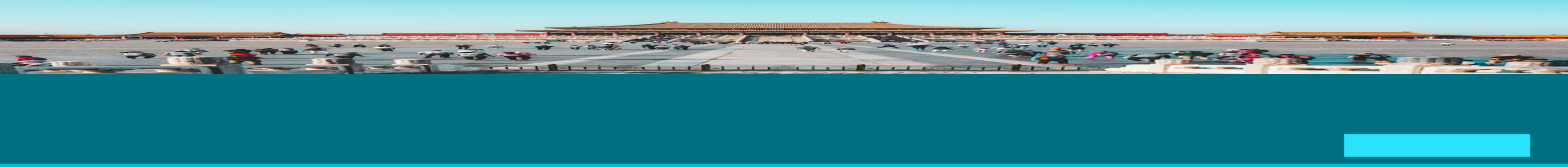
-- Anhui

Famous for granite peaks, hot springs, and sea-of-clouds formations. Sunrise at Bright

Summit Peak is legendary. Cable car: ¥80-90. Entry: ¥190.

8. Potala Palace

-- Lhasa, Tibet



Iconic 7th-century palace at 3,700m altitude. Former residence of the Dalai Lama. Entry:

¥200 (May-Oct), ¥100 (Nov-Apr). Requires Tibet Travel Permit.

9. Lijiang Old Town

-- Yunnan

800-year-old town of the Naxi minority with cobblestone streets, canals, and traditional

wooden architecture. Entry: ¥50 (ancient city maintenance fee).

10. Chengdu Research Base of Giant Panda Breeding

-- Sichuan

See giant pandas and red pandas in a natural habitat setting. Best visited early morning

(8-10 AM) when pandas are most active. Entry: ¥55.

Sources: Sources: [China National Tourism Administration](http://www.cnta.gov.cn) • [UNESCO World Heritage Centre](https://whc.unesco.org)

China High-Speed Rail Guide: Routes, Tickets, and

Tips

China's high-speed rail (HSR) network is the world's largest at 45,000+ km. It's the most convenient way to travel between major cities.

Train Types:

- * G-trains

- * (高铁): Fastest, up to 350 km/h. Beijing-Shanghai in 4.5 hours.

- * D-trains

- * (动车): Up to 250 km/h. More stops, slightly cheaper.

- * C-trains

- * (城际): Intercity services, 200-300 km/h.



How to Buy Tickets:

- * 12306 App

- * (铁路12306): Official app, accepts international credit cards. Book up to 15 days in advance.

- * Trip.com

- * : English-friendly interface, small booking fee.

- * Train station counters

- * : Bring passport. Available at all stations.

Popular Routes & Prices (Second Class):

- * Beijing → Shanghai: ¥553, 4.5 hours

- * Shanghai → Hangzhou: ¥73, 1 hour

- * Beijing → Xi'an: ¥515, 4.5 hours



* Guangzhou → Shenzhen: ¥75, 30 minutes

* Chengdu → Chongqing: ¥154, 1.5 hours

Tips for HSR Travel:

* Arrive 30-45 minutes early for security check and ticket verification

* Passport required for ticket purchase AND boarding

* Free luggage: 20kg adult, 10kg child

* Food carts on board, or bring your own (instant noodles are popular!)

* Power outlets available at every seat on G-trains

* Seat classes: Business (商务座), First (一等座), Second (二等座)

Sources: Sources: [12306 Official Railway](https://www.12306.cn) • [China National Tourism Administration](http://www.cnta.gov.cn)

Before You Fly to China: The Ultimate Pre-Trip

Checklist

I recently asked people what they were most worried about before traveling to China, and the answers were surprisingly consistent. Here are the most common concerns -- and practical solutions for each.

Top Concerns First-Time Visitors Have:

- * Payment:

- * How to use Alipay / WeChat Pay / international bank cards

- * Apps:

- * Chinese apps work differently than overseas versions

- * Language barrier:



* What to do when things go wrong

* Booking:

* How to book train tickets and attraction tickets

* Preparation:

* What to set up before landing

Before You Fly -- Essential Setup:

* Set up Alipay and WeChat Pay

* -- These are absolutely essential. Cash is rarely accepted in most places. Link your international credit card to both apps before you leave home.

* Add your international credit card

* to both Alipay and WeChat Pay if possible. Visa, Mastercard, and JCB are now supported.

* Download an offline translation app



* -- Google Translate doesn't work well in China. Use Apple Translate, Microsoft

Translator, or Pleco (best for Chinese).

* Save your hotel address in Chinese

* -- You'll need to show it to taxi drivers. Screenshot the Chinese address from your booking confirmation.

* Prepare a backup payment method

* -- Bring some cash (¥500-1000) just in case. ATMs at airports accept international cards.

* Check if your eSIM/roaming works in China

* -- Many international SIM cards don't work behind the Great Firewall. Get a China eSIM (Airalo, Holafly) or buy a local SIM at the airport.

* Know what doesn't work in China:

* Google, WhatsApp, Instagram, Facebook, YouTube, Twitter/X, Gmail -- all blocked.

Download a VPN before arrival, or use Chinese alternatives (Baidu, WeChat, Douyin).



After You Land -- First Steps:

- * Test payments with a small purchase first
- * -- Buy a drink or snack to make sure Alipay/WeChat Pay works before you rely on it.
- * Set up DiDi (滴滴出行) through Alipay or WeChat
- * -- This is China's Uber. It's integrated into both apps, so no separate download needed.
- * Always carry your passport
- * -- Required for train travel, hotel check-in, and sometimes SIM card purchase. Keep a photo on your phone as backup.
- * Don't rely only on Google Maps
- * -- It's inaccurate in China. Use Amap (高德地图) or Baidu Maps (百度地图) instead. Apple Maps works okay.
- * Book popular attractions earlier than you think
- * -- The Forbidden City, Terracotta Army, and other top sites often sell out days in



advance. Book via the official WeChat mini-program or Trip.com.

* Train tickets:

* Book via 12306 app or Trip.com. Passport required for purchase AND boarding. Arrive

30-45 min early.

Pro Tips From Experienced Travelers:

* Carry a power bank -- you'll use your phone for everything (payments, maps,

translation)

* Carry tissues -- many public restrooms don't provide toilet paper

* Learn basic phrases: 你好 (nǐ hǎo = hello), 谢谢 (xièxie = thank you), 多少钱 (duōshao

qián = how much), 厕所在哪里 (cèsuǒ zài nǎlǐ = where's the bathroom)

* Tap water is NOT drinkable -- buy bottled water or boil it

* China uses one time zone (UTC+8) for the entire country -- this means sunrise in

western China can be as late as 10 AM



* Bring a universal adapter -- China uses Type A, C, and I outlets

China is one of the safest and most convenient countries to travel in -- once you have the right apps set up. The learning curve is steep for the first 24 hours, but after that, everything becomes incredibly smooth.

Sources: Sources: Community experiences • [China](https://www.chinahighlights.com)

Highlights



Article 4

3 Days in Beijing: The Perfect Couple's Itinerary

Beijing is one of the most romantic and exciting cities in China for couples. From ancient palaces to hidden hutong bars, this 3-day itinerary covers the best of Beijing -- with real addresses, metro stops, and prices.

Day 1: Imperial Beijing -- History & Romance

8:30 AM -- Forbidden City (故宫)

Arrive right at opening to beat the crowds. Enter through the south gate (Meridian Gate 午门), walk through the golden halls, and exit through the north gate (Gate of Divine Prowess 神武门). Don't miss the Imperial Garden (御花园) at the back -- ancient cypresses and rockeries make it the most romantic corner.



8:30-17:00 (Apr-Oct) / 8:30-16:30 (Nov-Mar) | ¥60 (Apr-Oct) / ¥40 (Nov-Mar) | ! Must book

online 7 days ahead via WeChat mini-program "故宫博物院"

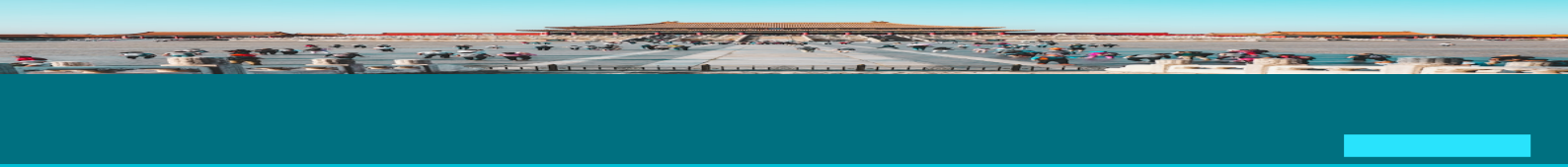
11:00 AM -- Jingshan Park (景山公园)

Walk out the north gate of the Forbidden City and cross the street. Climb the hill (10 minutes) for the best panoramic view of the entire palace complex. The top pavilion is THE photo spot -- the golden roofs stretching out below you is unforgettable.

6:30-21:00 | ¥2

12:30 PM -- Lunch at Guijie Ghost Street (簋街)

Take a DiDi 10 minutes east. Guijie is Beijing's most famous food street -- 1km of restaurants lit up with red lanterns. The signature dish is spicy crayfish (麻辣小龙虾) -- messy, fun, and perfect for couples to share. Recommended: Hu Da (胡大饭馆), the most famous crayfish spot on the street.



11:00-次日6:00 (簋街很多店24小时营业) | ¥100-150/两人

2:30 PM -- Nanluoguxiang (南锣鼓巷)

A 800-year-old hutong alley turned into Beijing's most charming pedestrian street.

Browse quirky shops, grab bubble tea, and explore the side hutongs -- Yuer Hutong

(雨儿胡同) and Mao'er Hutong (帽儿胡同) are quieter and more authentic. Try the famous

文宇奶店 (Wenyu Dairy) for traditional Beijing yogurt.

全天开放, 店铺约10:00-22:00 | 免费入场

5:30 PM -- Houhai Lake (后海) Sunset & Evening

Walk west from Nanluoguxiang (15 minutes) to Houhai Lake. Rent a paddle boat (脚踏船)

and watch the sunset over the lake -- the willow trees, traditional houses, and golden

light make it incredibly romantic. After returning the boat, stroll along the bar street

(后海酒吧街). Recommended: 望海楼 (Wanghai Lou) for a quiet lakeside drink, or 烤肉季



(Rouji) for famous Beijing lamb BBQ since 1848.

全天开放 | 脚踏船 ¥60-80/小时 | 酒吧 18:00-次日2:00

Day 2: Great Wall & Date Night

8:00 AM -- Mutianyu Great Wall (慕田峪长城)

The most couple-friendly section of the Great Wall. Less crowded than Badaling, beautifully restored, and has a fun toboggan slide down. Take the cable car up to Tower 14, walk east to Tower 20 (best views, fewer people), then walk back and take the toboggan slide down from Tower 6. Allow 3-4 hours total.

Getting there:

Book a private car via DiDi (¥200-300 round trip, 1.5 hours) or take bus 916 Express from Dongzhimen Bus Station (东直门公交站) to Huairou, then transfer to bus H23 (total ¥15, 2 hours).



7:30-18:00 (Apr-Oct) / 8:00-17:00 (Nov-Mar) | ¥40 entry + ¥120 往返缆车 / ¥100 滑道下山

6:30 PM -- Date Night Dinner

Back in the city, dress up for a special dinner. Choose one:

* Dali Courtyard (大理院子)

* -- Hidden in a hutong near Nanluoguxiang. Yunnan cuisine in a candlelit courtyard with fairy lights. The grilled fish and wild mushroom hotpot are incredible. Intimate, romantic, and very "Beijing." Reserve 2 days ahead.

11:30-14:00, 17:30-22:00 | ¥150-200/两人 | 建议提前2天预约

* Capital M

* -- Fine dining at Qianmen with direct Tiananmen views through floor-to-ceiling windows. Western cuisine, excellent wine list. Perfect for anniversaries or proposals.

11:30-14:30, 18:00-22:30 | ¥400-600/两人 | 建议提前预约



9:30 PM -- Cocktails at Migas (米家思)

End the night at Beijing's best rooftop bar. On the 6th floor of Nali Patio in Sanlitun,

Migas has an open-air terrace with views over the neon-lit Taikoo Li complex. The

sangria and gin cocktails are excellent. On weekends, there's a DJ after 10 PM.

18:00-次日2:00 | ¥70-100/人/杯

Day 3: Culture, Food & Hidden Gems

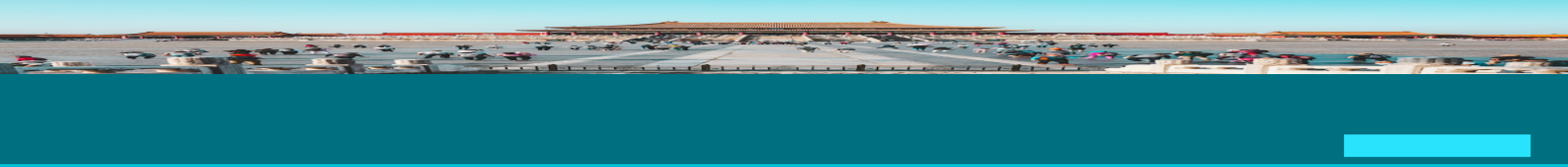
8:00 AM -- Temple of Heaven (天坛)

More beautiful and less crowded than the Forbidden City. The Circular Mound Altar

(圜丘坛) is designed so sound echoes perfectly -- stand in the center and whisper to each

other, the acoustics are magical. Watch locals doing tai chi, dancing, and playing cards

in the long corridors.



6:00-21:00 | ¥15 (联票¥34含祈年殿/回音壁/圜丘)

11:30 AM -- Xiaolongbao at Din Tai Fung (鼎泰丰)

World-famous Taiwanese soup dumplings. Order the pork xiaolongbao (鲜肉小笼) and watch the chefs fold each one with 18 folds through the glass kitchen. The trick: bite a small hole, sip the soup, then dip in vinegar-ginger sauce. It's a fun shared experience.

11:00-21:30 | ¥100-150/两人

2:00 PM -- 798 Art District (798艺术区)

A massive former electronics factory complex turned into Beijing's coolest art zone. Wander through contemporary galleries, street art installations, and hipster cafes. Best spots for couples: UCCA Center for Contemporary Art (尤伦斯当代艺术中心), the graffiti walls, and the rooftop cafe at At Cafe. Great for Instagram photos.



10:00-17:00 (各画廊时间不同) | 免费入场, 个别展馆 ¥10-30

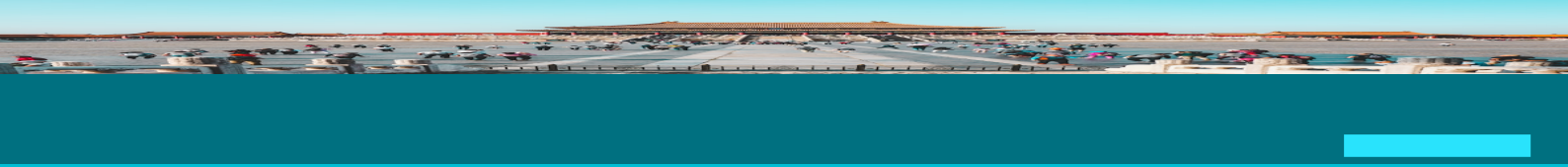
4:30 PM -- Traditional Tea at Wufu Tea House (五福茶艺馆)

After walking around 798, sit down for a proper Chinese tea ceremony. The staff will guide you through brewing oolong or pu'er tea in a gaiwan (盖碗). It's a calm, intimate experience -- perfect for slowing down together. Learn the "Gongfu" brewing method and taste 3-4 different teas.

9:30-21:00 | ¥80-150/两人 (含茶位费和茶点)

7:00 PM -- Sunset Cocktails at China World Summit Wing (国贸大酒店80层)

End the trip on the 80th floor of Beijing's tallest building. The Atmosphere Bar has floor-to-ceiling windows with a 360 deg view of the entire city -- the CBD skyline, the mountains in the west, and on clear days, the Great Wall in the distance. Arrive before sunset (around 6:30 PM in summer) to watch the city light up.



17:00-次日1:00 | ¥100-150/杯 | 建议穿Smart Casual

Couple's Tips:

* Best photo spots: Jingshan Park (Forbidden City view), Temple of Heaven echo wall,

Great Wall Tower 20, Houhai Lake sunset, 798 graffiti walls, 80th floor skyline

* Most romantic moments: Paddle boat on Houhai at sunset, whispering at the Temple

of Heaven echo wall, rooftop cocktails at Migas

* Budget: ¥600-800/天/两人 (经济) | ¥1500+/天/两人 (享受)

* 交通: 地铁 + 滴滴出行 | 办一张一卡通交通卡 (地铁站可买)

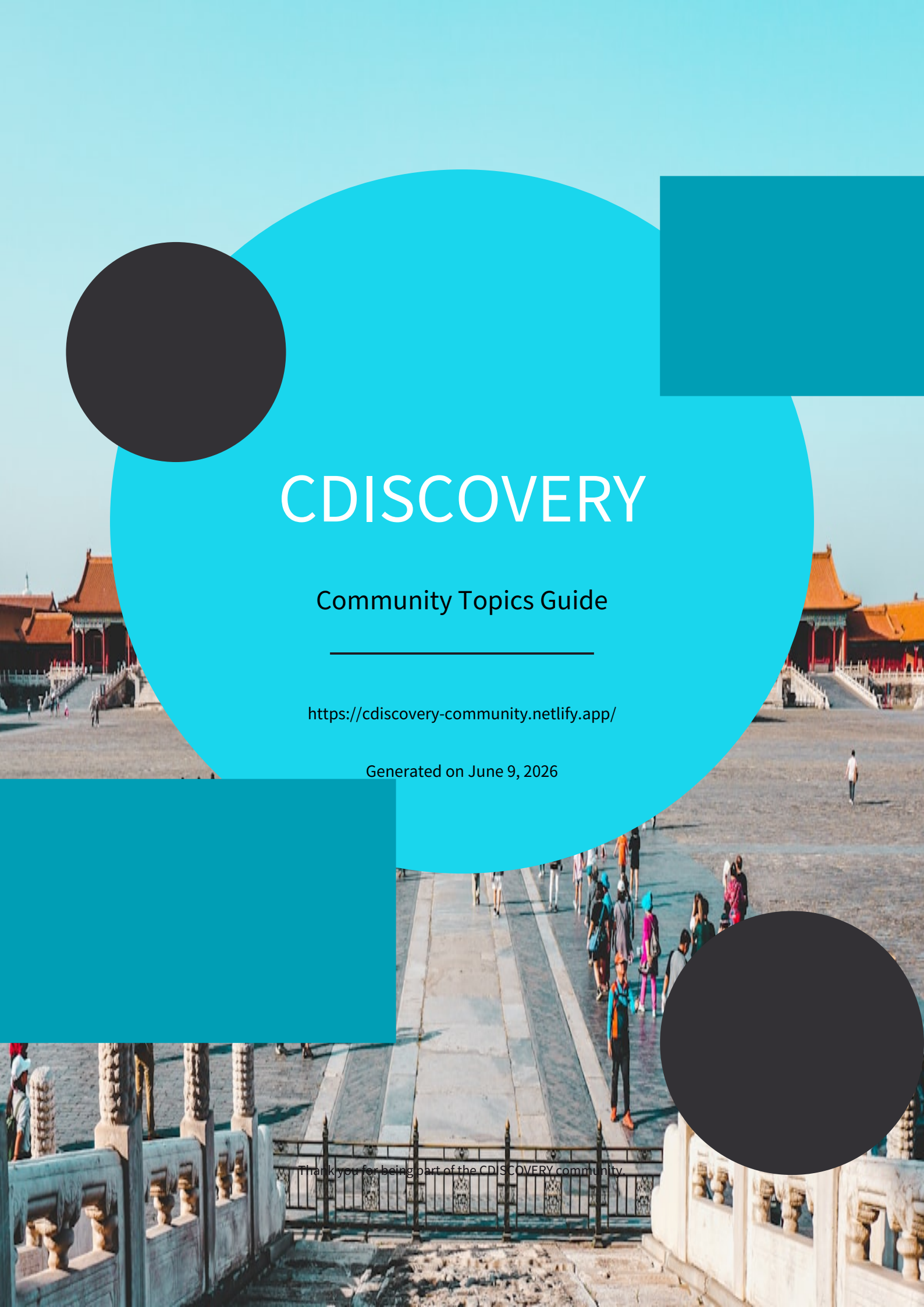
* 必备App: 大众点评 (找餐厅)、小红书 (找小众景点)、高德地图 (导航)

* 最佳季节: 春天4-5月 / 秋天9-10月 | 避开暑假 (7-8月太热) 和冬天 (12-2月太冷)

Sources: Sources: Community experiences • [The Beijinger](https://www.thebeijinger.com)

• [Trip.com](https://www.trip.com) • [高德地图](https://www.amap.com)

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Community Topics Guide

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Thank you for being part of the CDISCOVERY community